

Anatomy of a Public Payroll

Salary year 2025-26

Every employee salary record the university publishes, for 2024-25 and 2025-26 - extracted, verified, and read as one workforce.

27,004

employee records

\$2.15B

total base payroll

\$61,465

median salary

\$79,549

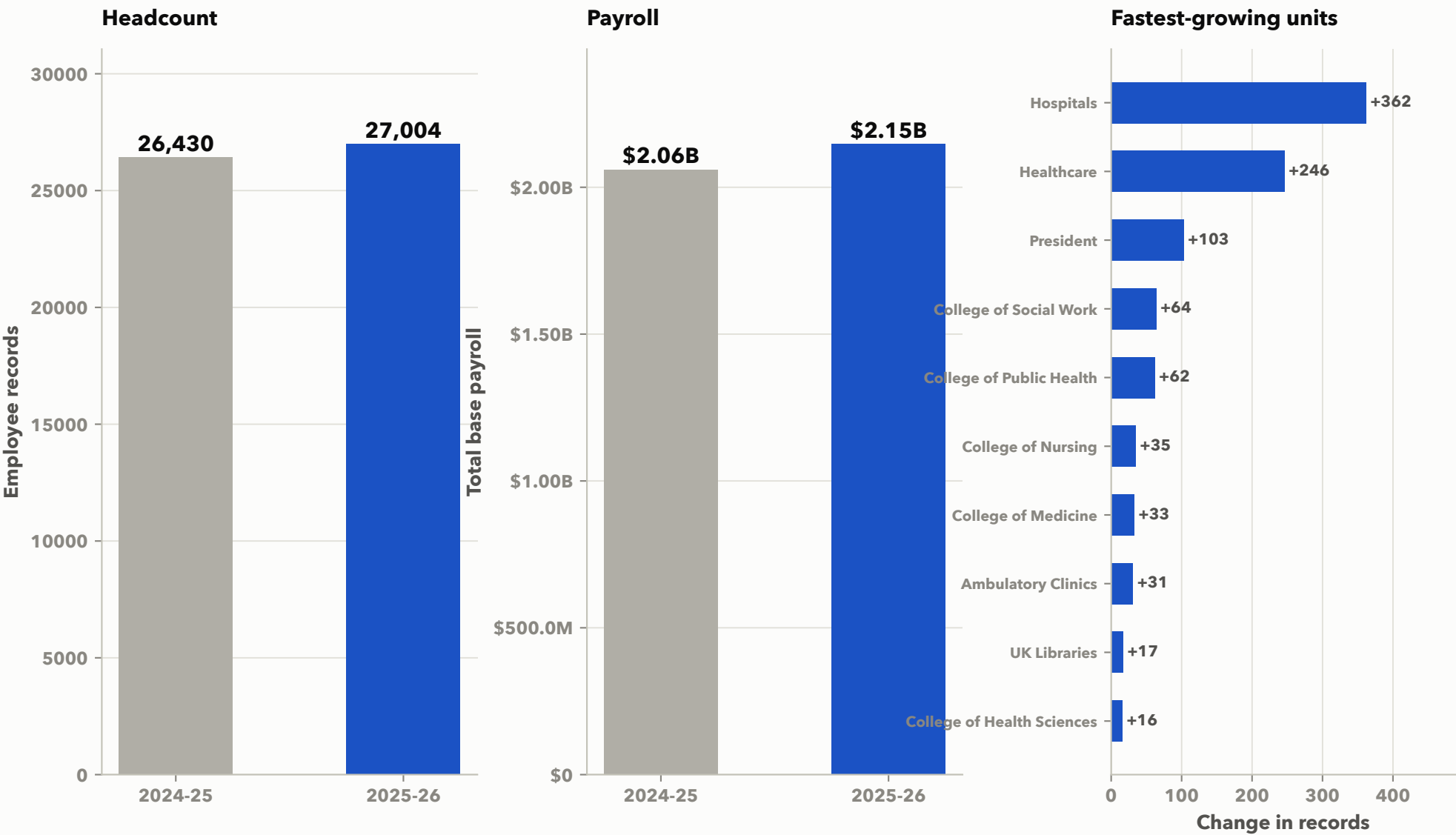
mean salary

Payroll grew +4.2% in a year - and the gap between those last two numbers is where this report starts.

Source: University of Kentucky 2025-26 salary database (public record, released under the Kentucky Open Records Act). Base salary only.
Data retrieved 2026-08-04. 34 administrative units, 765 departments, 3,535 distinct job titles.
No individual employee is named in this document.

The payroll grew \$87.1M in a single year

Between 2024-25 and 2025-26 the university added 574 employee records (+2.2%) and \$87.1M of base salary (+4.2%). Payroll grew faster than headcount, so the average record also became more expensive - not simply more numerous.

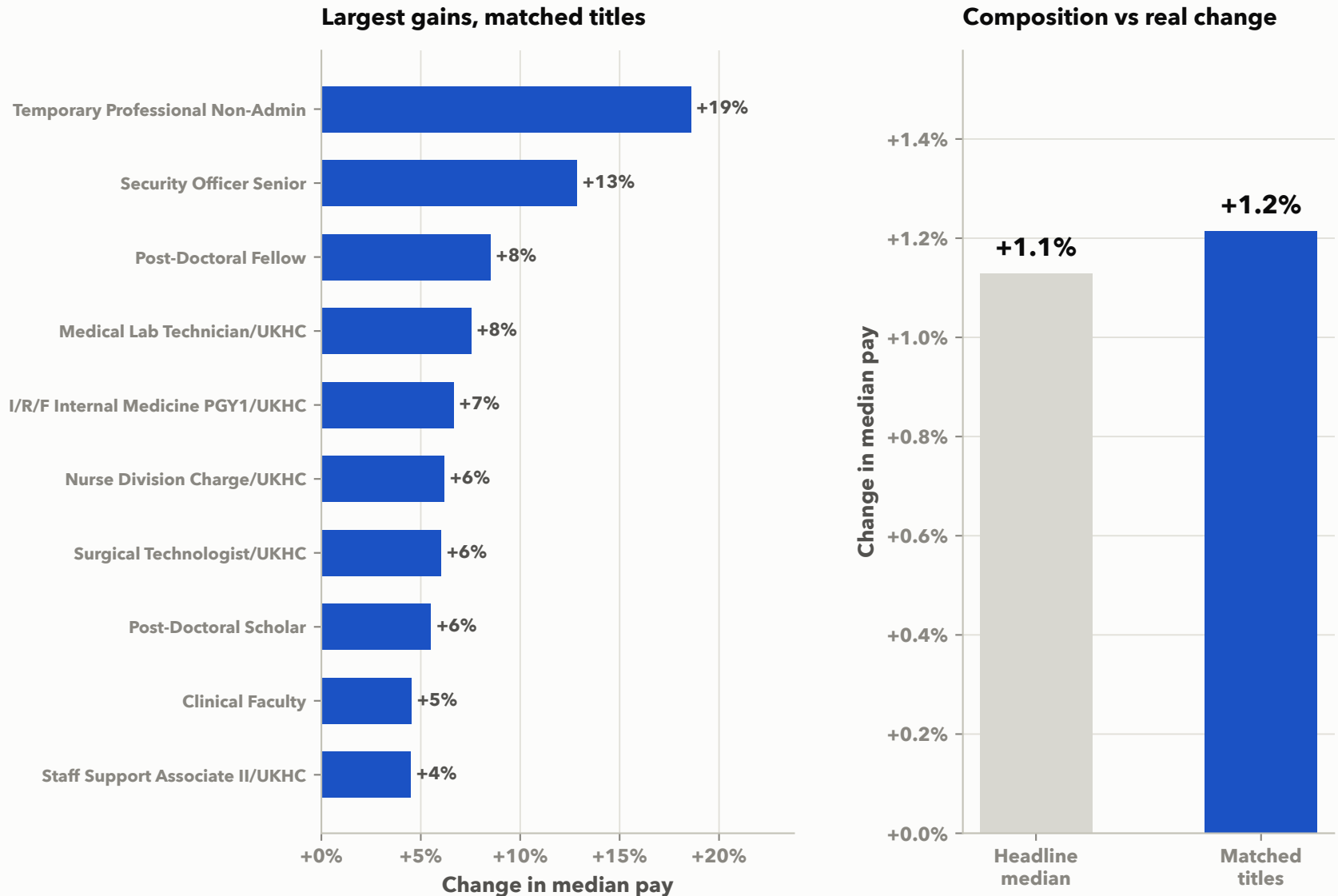


Median salary +1.1%; full-time median +2.0%. Nominal dollars - not inflation-adjusted.

Most of the pay rise is real - but not all of it

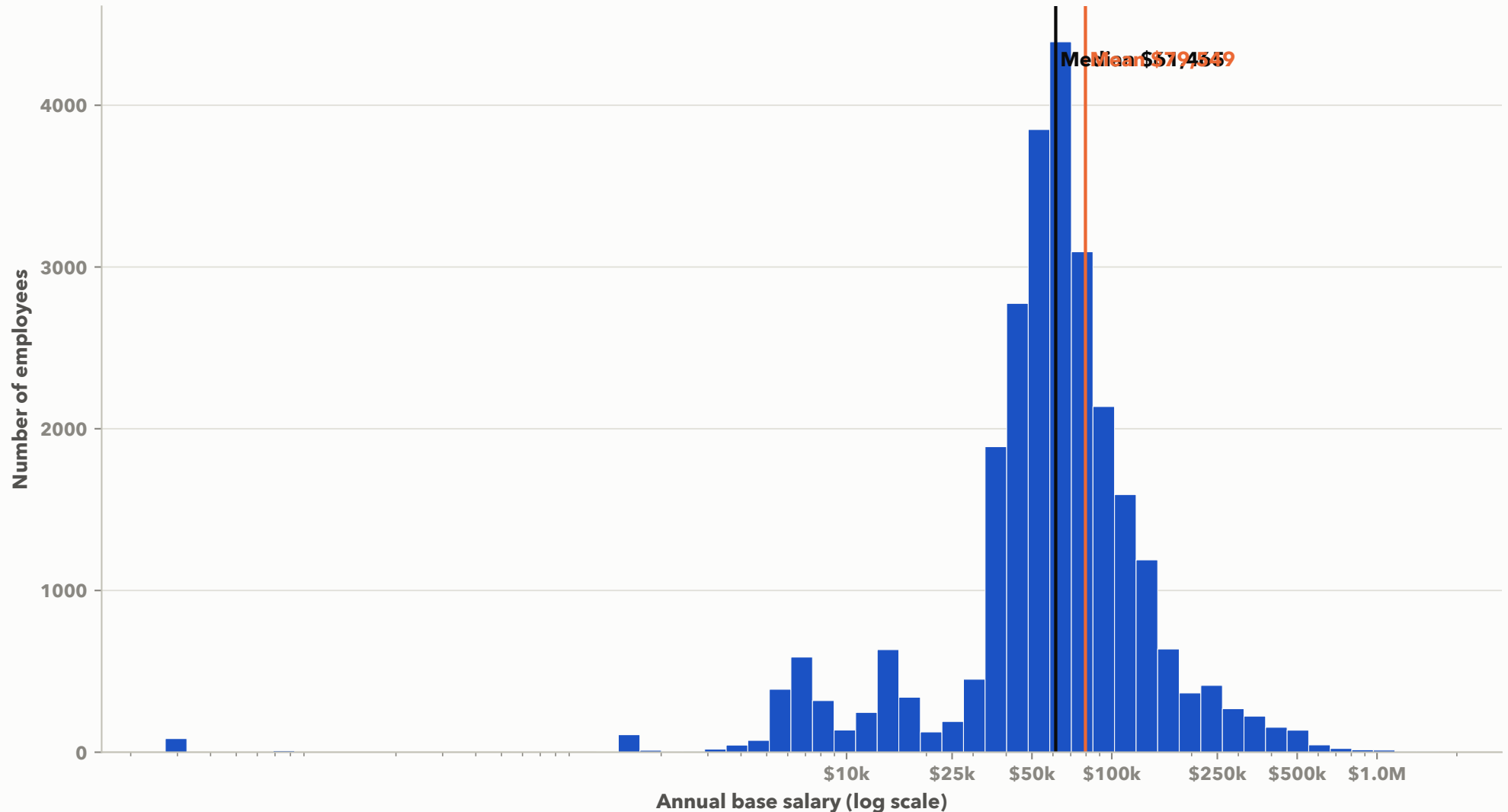
A rising median does not prove anyone got a raise: it also rises when the university hires more well-paid roles.

Comparing the same job title in both years (160 titles with at least 20 people in each), the median change was +1.2% and 68% of titles rose.



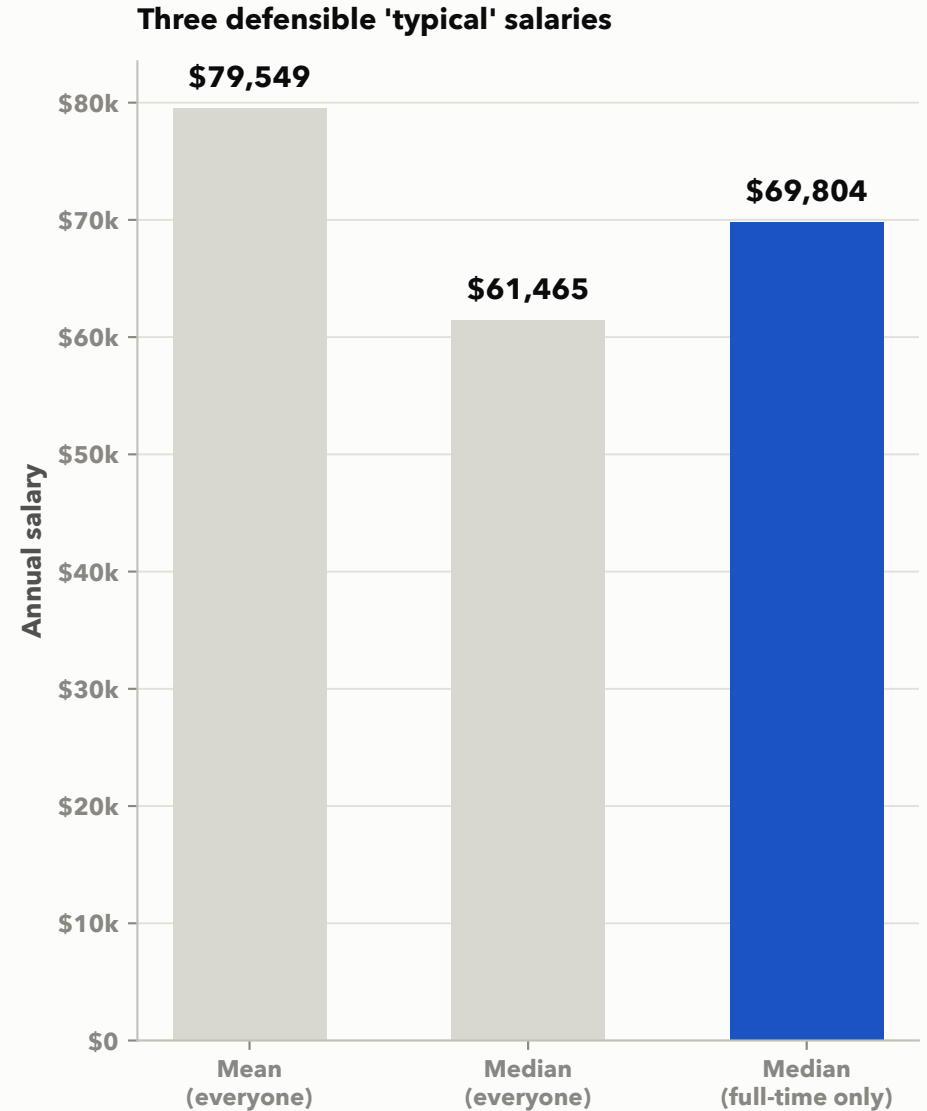
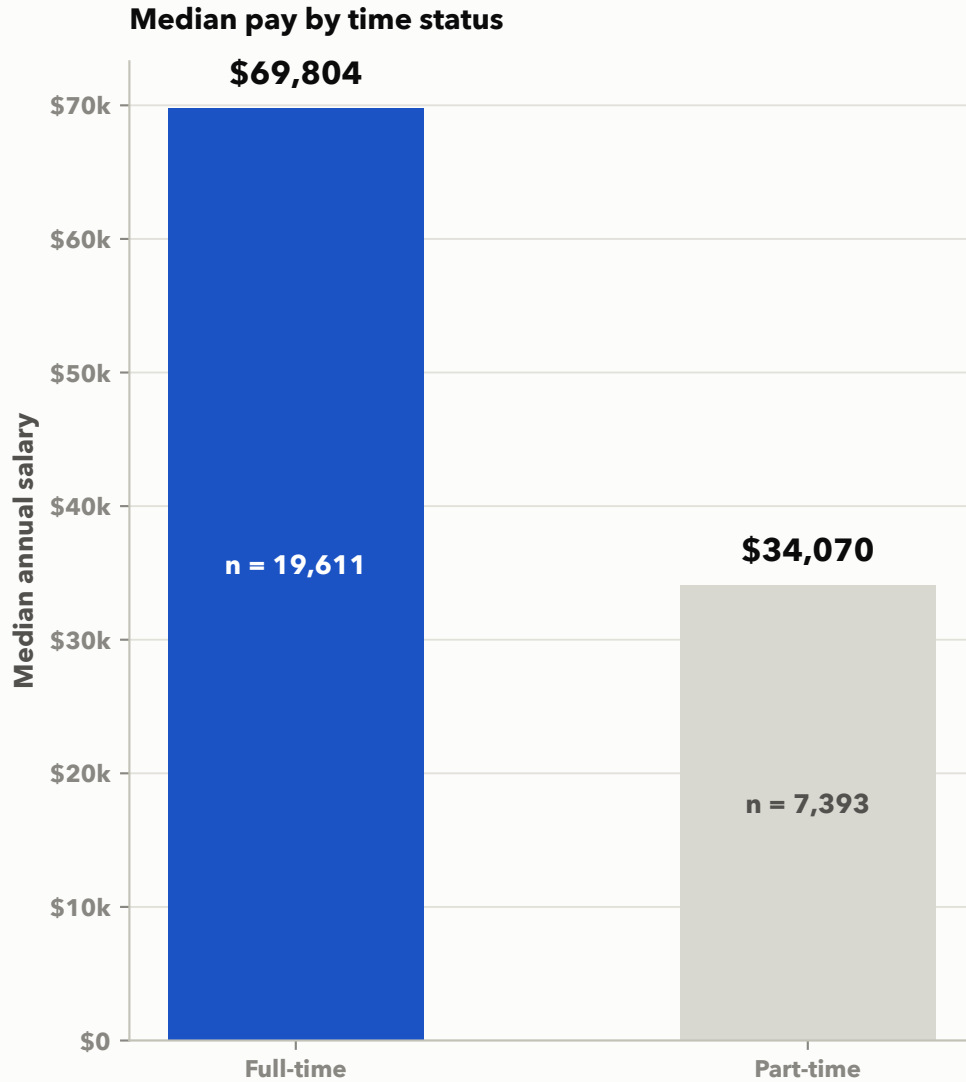
Most employees earn far less than the average

The mean salary is \$79,549, but the median is \$61,465 - a gap of \$18,084. A long tail of high earners pulls the average above what a typical employee actually makes, so 'average salary' overstates the middle of this workforce.



One in five records is part-time, which distorts every average

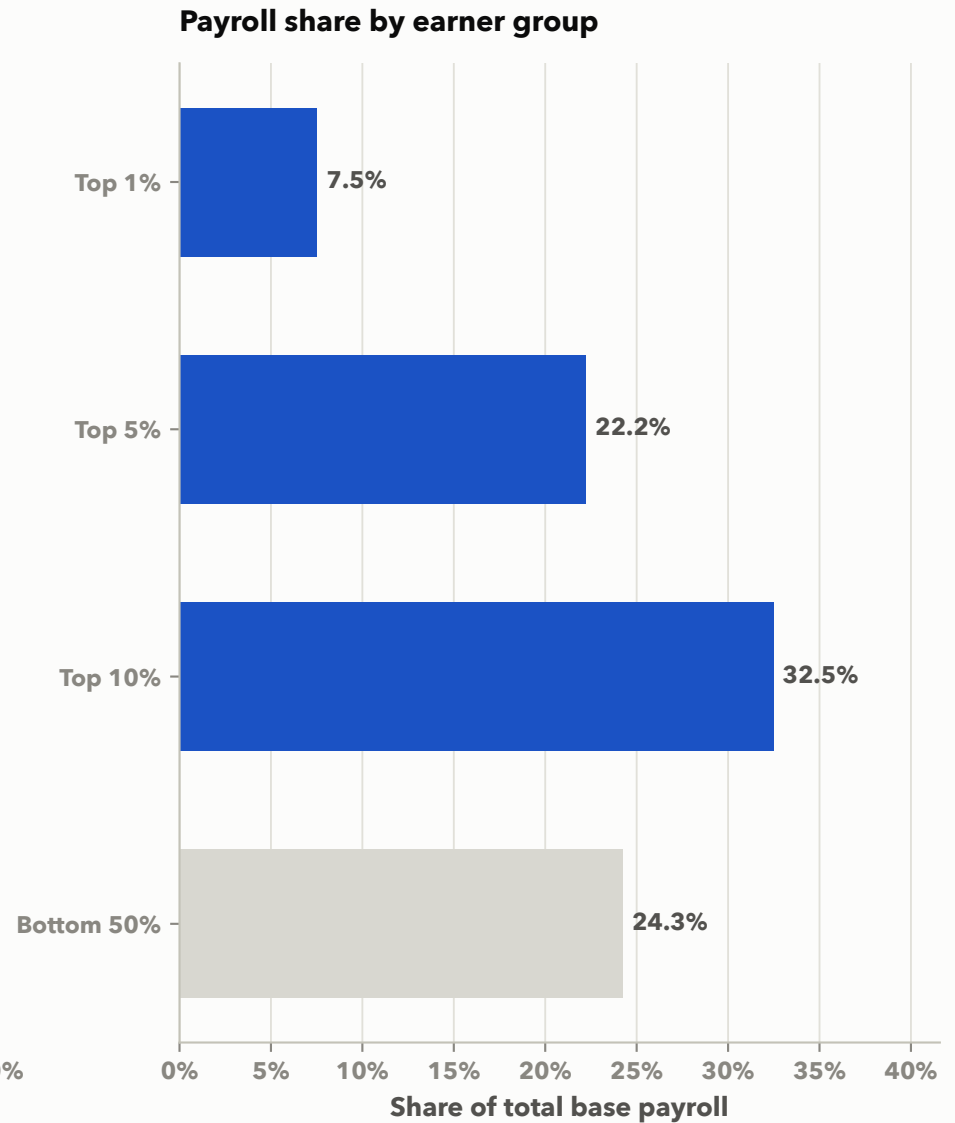
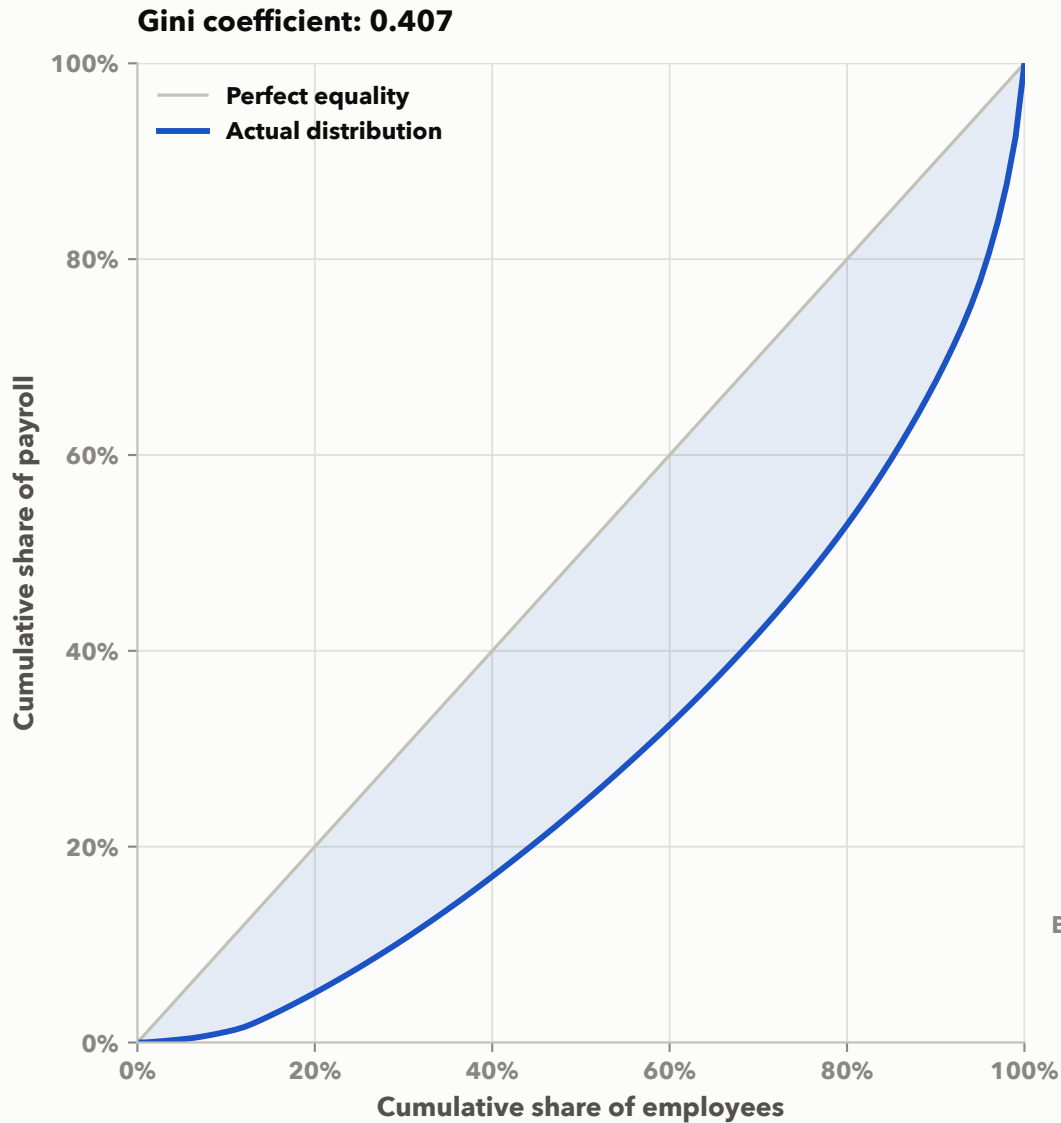
7,393 of 27,004 records (27%) are part-time. Because the source reports FTE-adjusted annual pay, a half-time employee shows half a salary. Comparing the two groups without separating them understates typical pay.



Highlighted bar is the figure this report uses when describing typical pay.

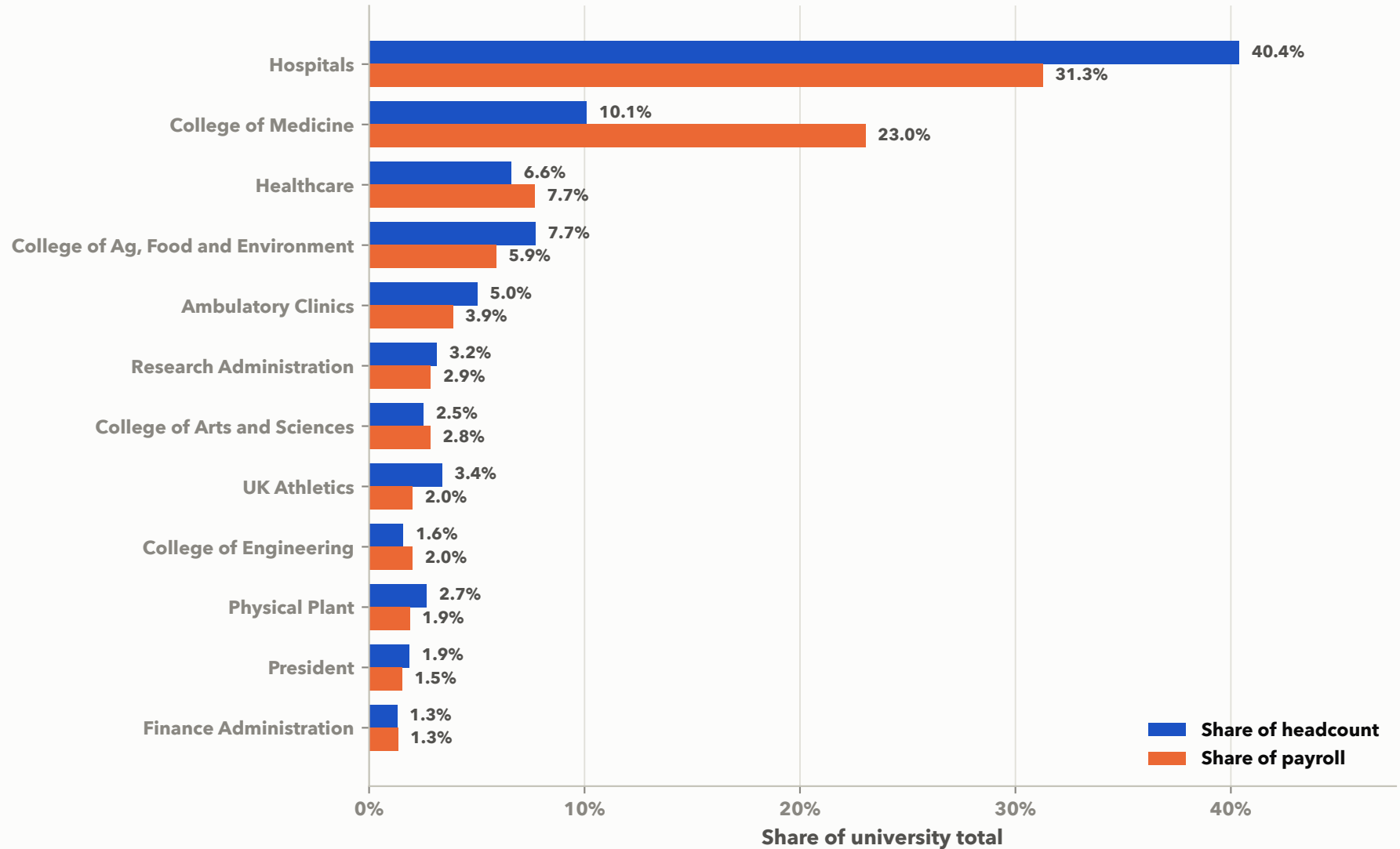
The top 10% of earners take 32% of the payroll

Plotted as a Lorenz curve, the further the line bows below the diagonal, the more concentrated the pay.
The top 1% of records (270 people) account for 7.5% of all base salary; the bottom half accounts for 24.3%.



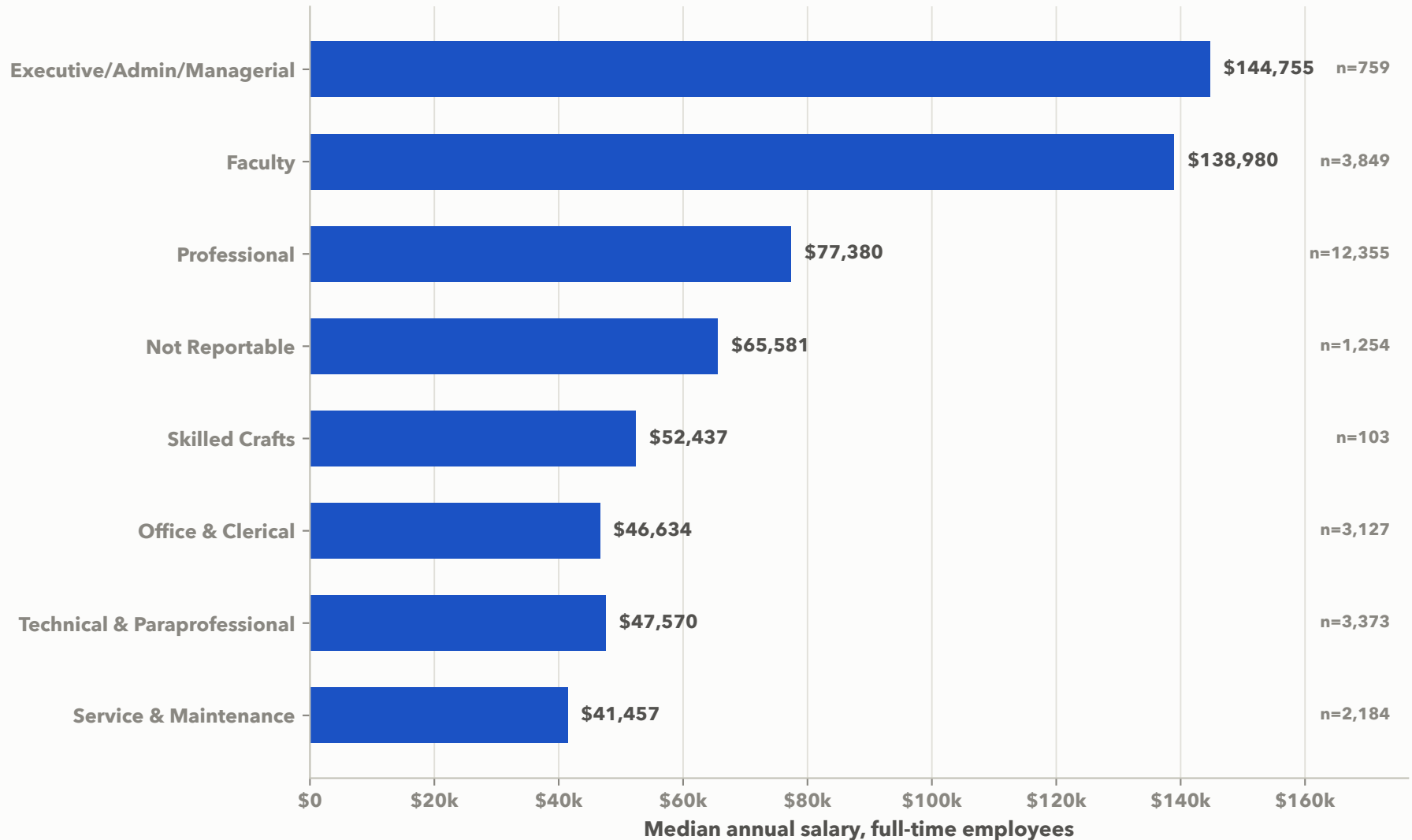
UK is a health system with a university attached

Hospitals alone accounts for 10,909 records (40% of headcount) and 31% of base payroll.
Comparing the two bars shows which units are staff-heavy relative to their pay, and which are the reverse.



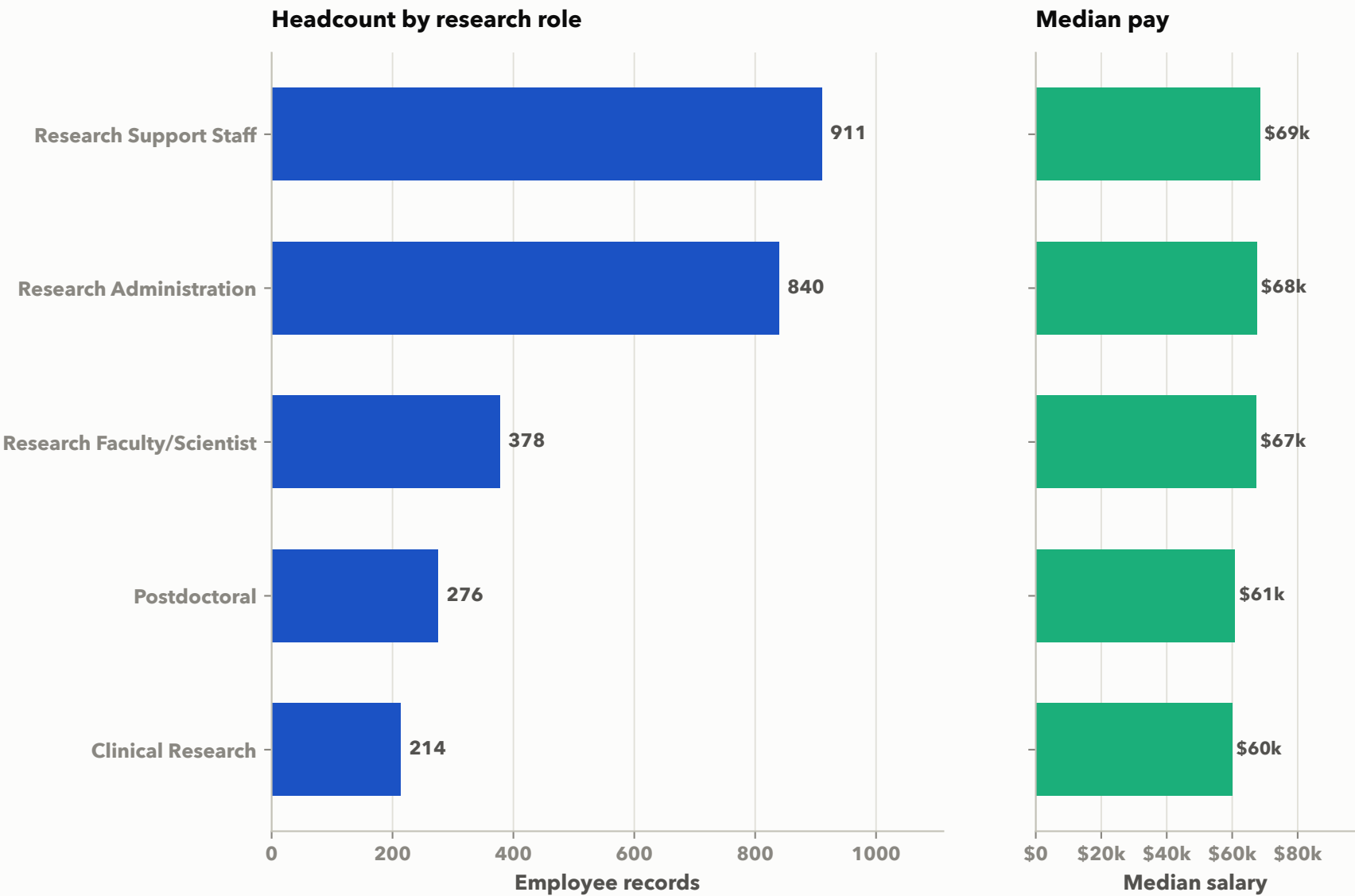
Median pay by occupational category

The federal EEO categories the university reports against separate the workforce into broad occupational groups. Full-time medians are shown alongside the all-records median, since part-time concentration differs sharply by group.



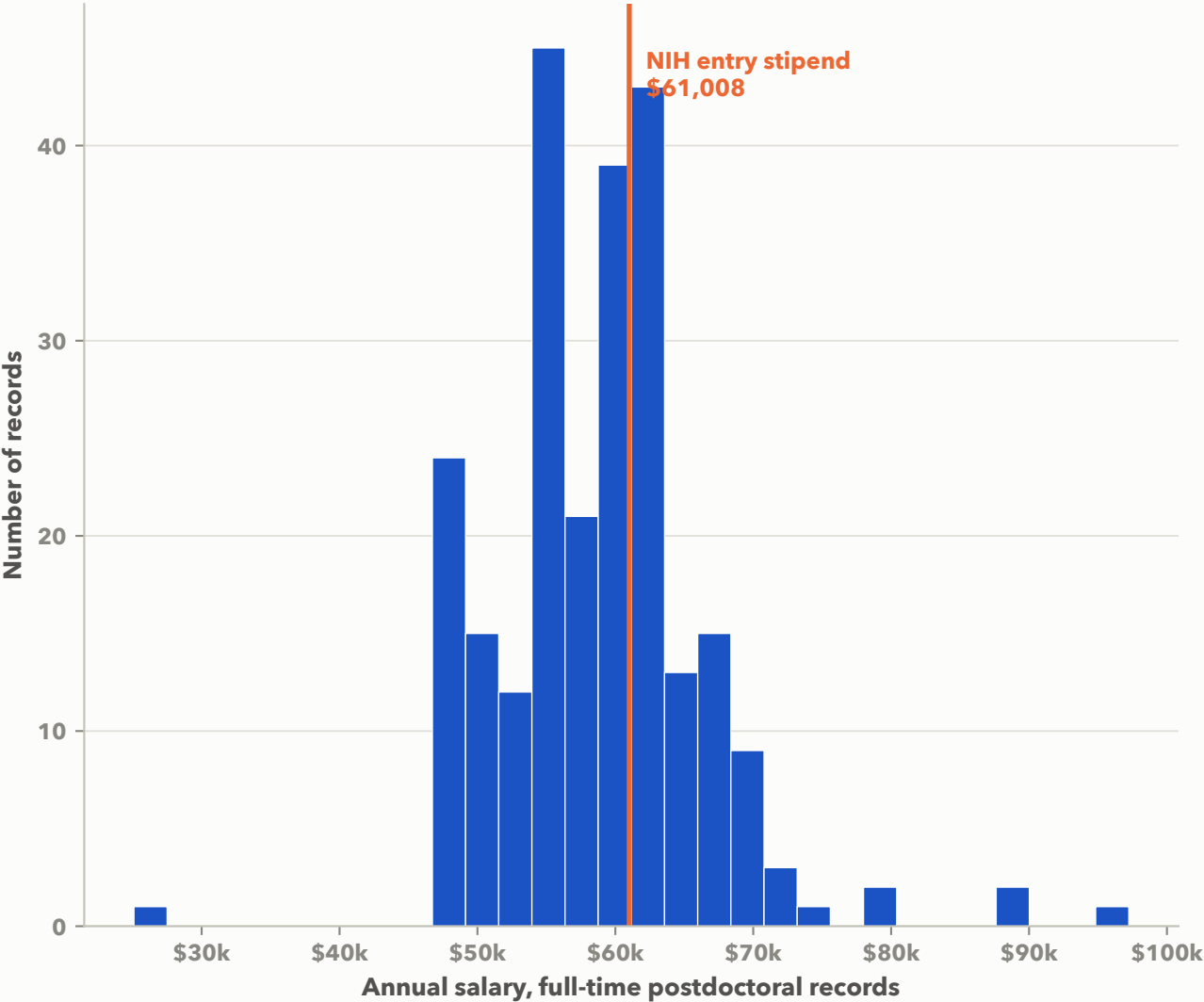
2,619 records staff the research mission

Roles coded to research - postdocs, research scientists and support staff, clinical research, and research administration - make up 9.7% of headcount and 8.5% of base payroll, with a median of \$63,120.



Postdoctoral pay against the NIH entry stipend

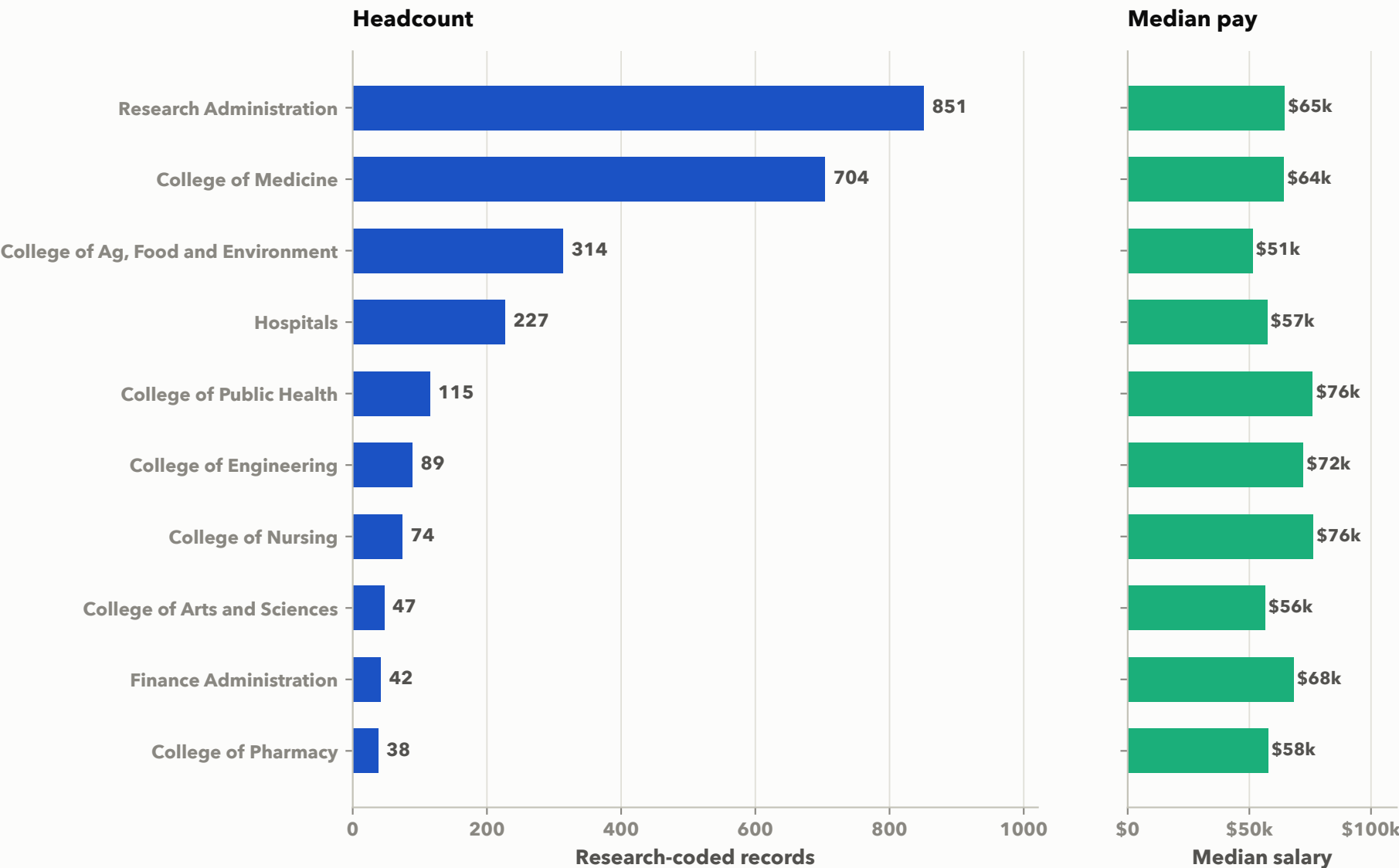
UK's 276 postdoctoral records have a median of \$60,000. The NIH NRSA entry-level stipend for FY2024 is \$61,008 - the standard external floor for postdoctoral pay. 59% of full-time postdocs sit below it.



Postdoctoral pay	
Records	276
Full-time	246
Median	\$60,000
Mean	\$59,281
Lowest	\$25,092
Highest	\$97,235

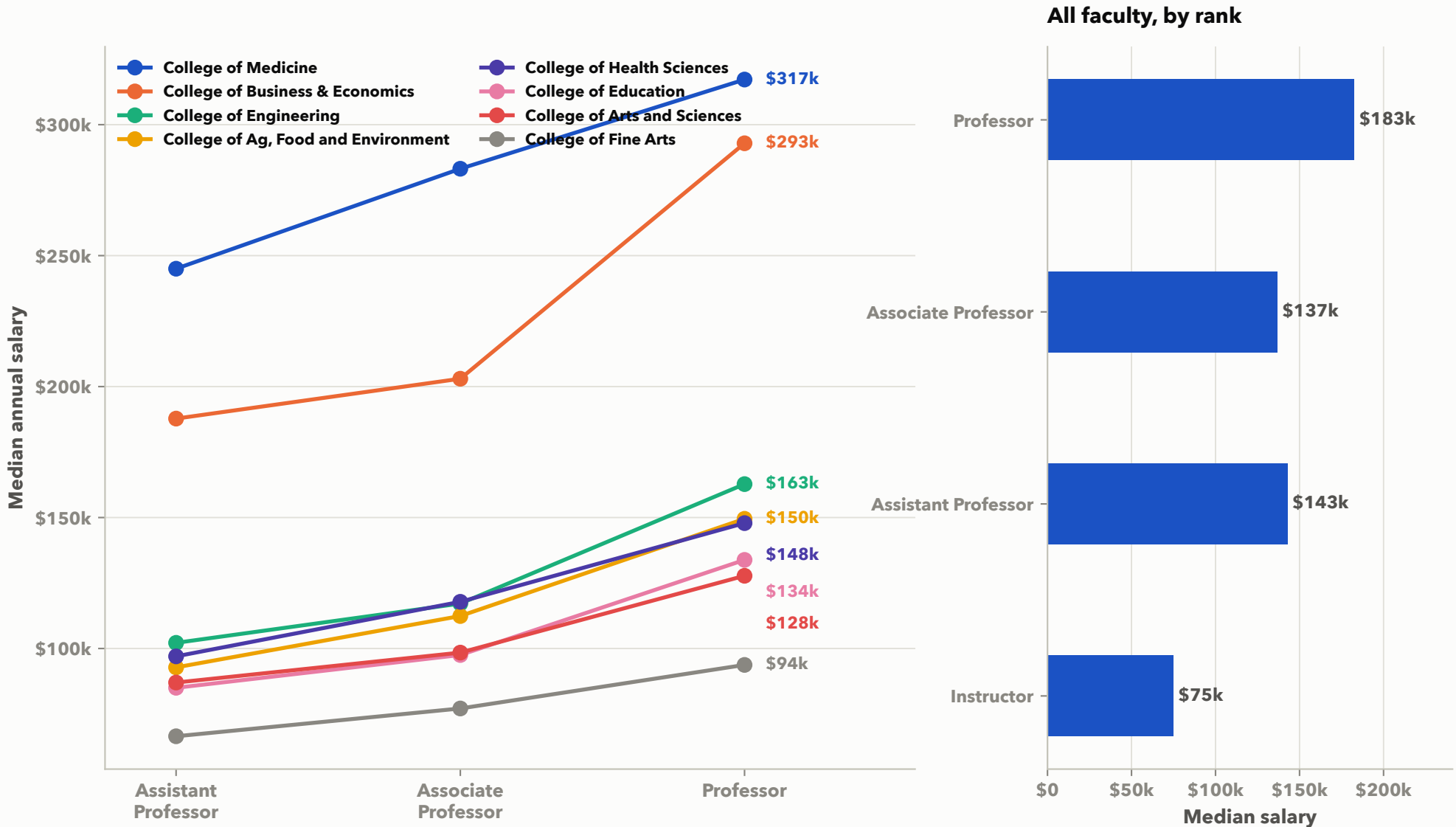
The research workforce is concentrated, not spread evenly

Research Administration holds the largest share of research-coded staff (851 records).
Median pay varies widely across units, reflecting very different mixes of postdocs, technicians and senior scientists.



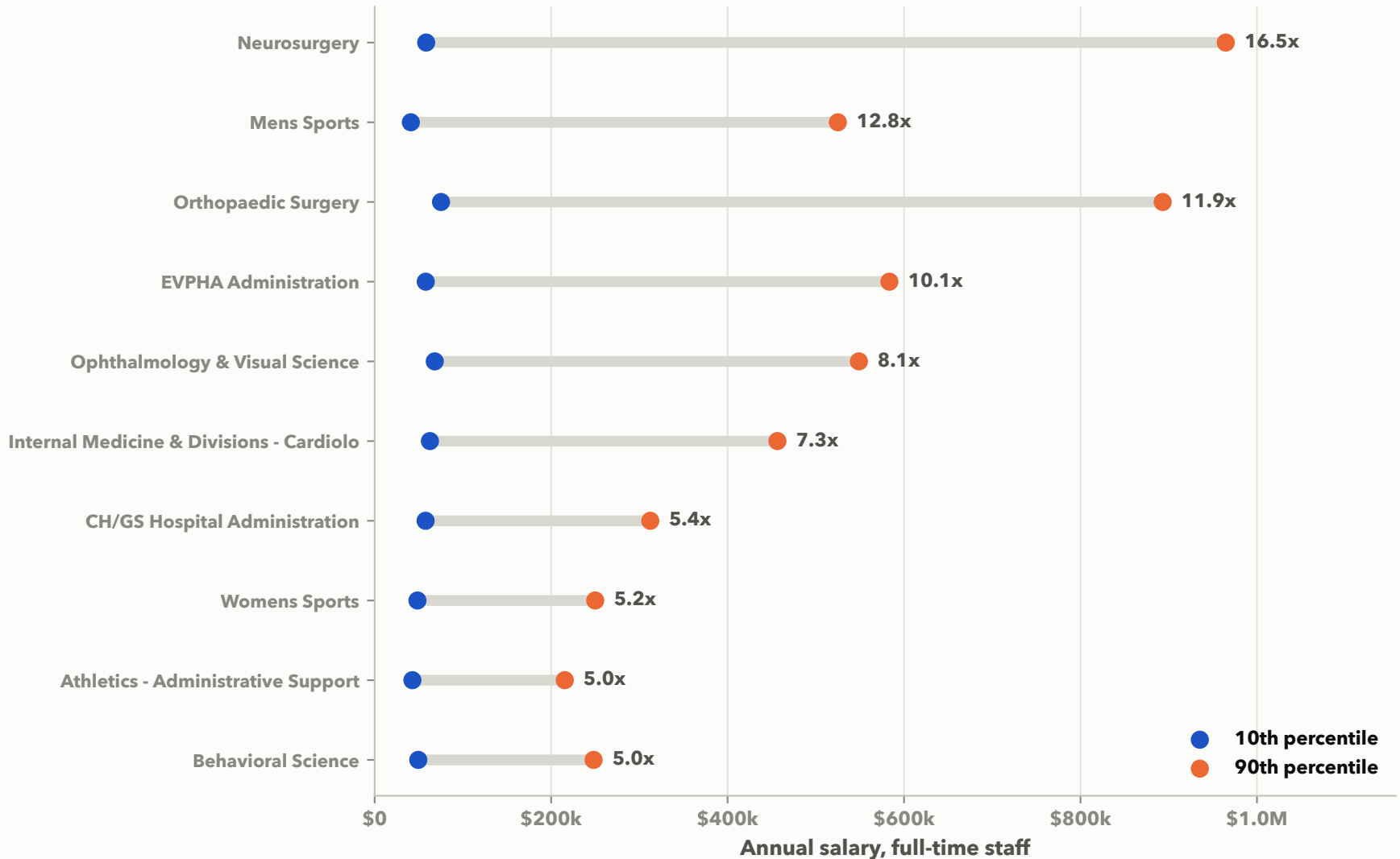
Promotion is worth far more in some colleges than others

Across the university a full professor's median pay is 1.28x an assistant professor's. But the slope of that ladder differs sharply by college - each line below tracks median pay across the three tenure-track ranks.



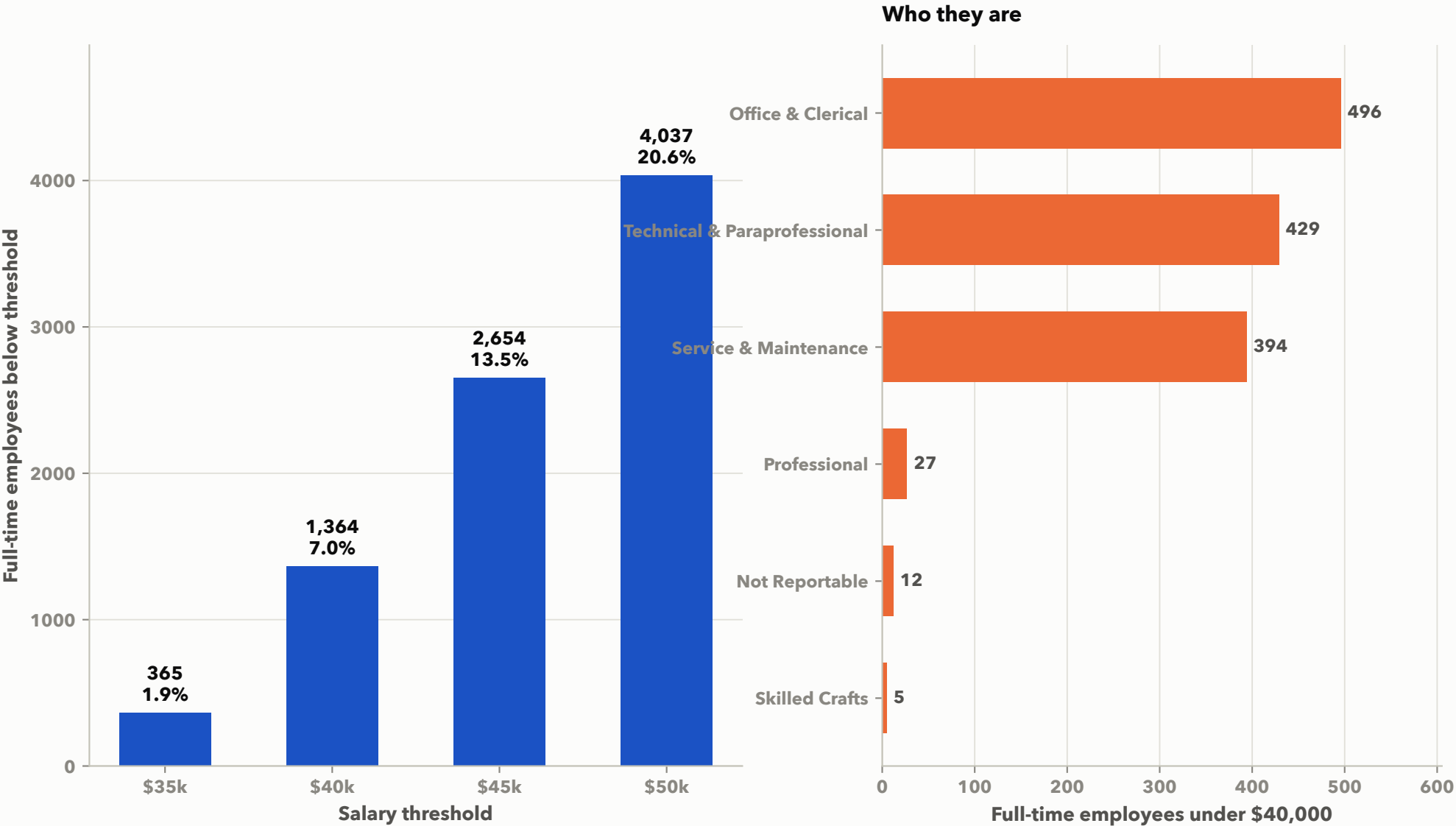
Some departments contain their own pay hierarchy

Among departments with at least 30 full-time staff, these have the widest internal gap between their 90th and 10th percentile earners - typically clinical or academic units where trainees, staff and senior faculty share one department code.



1,364 full-time employees earn under \$40,000

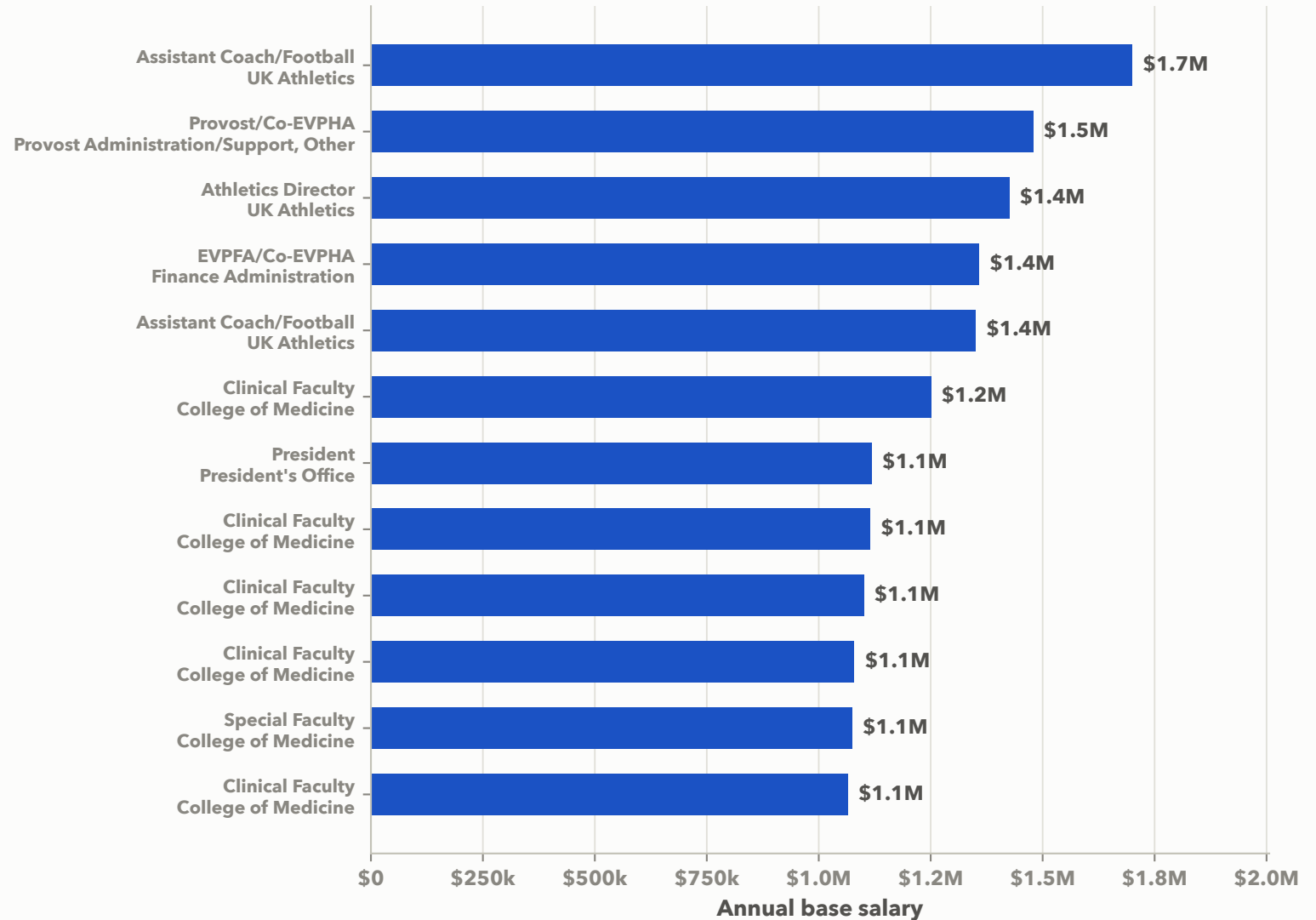
That is 7.0% of the full-time workforce. Restricting to full-time records removes the FTE effect, so these are genuinely low full-year salaries rather than part-time artefacts.



Base salary excludes shift differentials, overtime and benefits, which materially affect take-home pay in service roles.

The highest-paid roles are athletics and clinical leadership

Positions are identified by job title and unit only - no individual is named. Base salary alone understates total compensation at this end of the distribution, where supplements, incentives and outside income are common.



How this was built, and what it cannot tell you

DATA SOURCE

The university publishes each salary year (2024-25, 2025-26) through a Caspio search application. It offers no export and no API, so each dataset was reconstructed by driving the same AJAX endpoint the page itself uses, walking every result page. Extracts are resumable and cached page-by-page.

MISSING DATA

2024-25: Rank=21,836
2025-26: Rank=22,213
Academic rank is blank for two reasons, counted separately:
Not applicable 22,202
Reported 4,791
Not reported 11

VALIDATION

Computed statistics were checked against figures published independently from the same source dataset:

record_count	expected	26,430	computed	26,430	PASS
mean_salary	expected	77,981	computed	77,981	PASS
median_salary	expected	60,779	computed	60,779	PASS
count_over_500k	expected	130	computed	128	PASS

WHAT THIS DATA IS NOT

- **Base salary only.** It excludes benefits, bonuses, clinical incentive pay, shift differentials, overtime, and athletics supplements. Total compensation is higher than shown, especially at the extremes.
- **FTE-adjusted.** Part-time staff show reduced annual figures that do not indicate a low rate of pay. Full-time-only cuts are used wherever pay levels are compared.
- **Records, not people.** An employee holding two appointments appears twice. In 2025-26, 502 name combinations appear on more than one record, but common names collide, so this is an approximation and no exact person count is claimed.
- **Change is measured on records, not individuals.** The source carries no employee identifier, so matched job titles are used to control for a changing mix of roles.
- **Nominal dollars.** Figures are not adjusted for inflation.

DELIBERATE OMISSIONS

- **No employee is named anywhere in this report.**
- **No gender, race, or other demographic attribute is inferred.** The dataset contains none, and estimating them from names would not support defensible conclusions.